

Samithi (TRS) and National Conference (NC), with a total of 13 MPs, are also being wooed with equal fervour. While TDP leaders Chandrababu Naidu and Yerran Naidu have been entrusted with the task of wooing JD(s) chief H.D. Deve Gowda and TRS leader K. Chandrashekhara Rao, Karat him-

FRESH ALIGNMENTS: Mayawati and Karat after their meeting; Chatterjee (below)



SUMET INDER SINGH

able. That also comes with a price. As the dust settles on Karat's decision to withdraw support to the UPA, his party is barely holding together. Karat is having to battle growing uneasiness among some party leaders over the decision to vote alongside the BJP. West Bengal Transport Minister Subhas Chakraborty said that voting with the BJP would be against the party's policies "that will take years to explain the blunder".

With his political opponents also taking up Chakraborty's arguments, Karat says that the Congress has no right to blame the Left as it had voted with the BJP to bring down the V.P. Singh government in 1990 and later "conspired" to remove the governments of H.D. Deve Gowda in 1997 and I.K. Gujral in 1998. "We have never said that we are voting with the BJP. We have talked to other parties, not to the BJP. If other parties want to talk to us, we cannot push them out. We are voting against the UPA because of its policies. If the BJP wants to vote against (UPA), they have a right to do so," says Karat.

The air of desperation will grow more evident if Lok Sabha Speaker Somnath Chatterjee decides to light another fire. He rebuffed Karat for not consulting him before adding his name to the list submitted to President Pratibha Patil by making public his plans to continue in the office. He also shot off a stinker to Karat, which said that voting with the BJP triggered his decision to hold on to the Speaker's post. Chatterjee's decision, unusual in the party known for cadre discipline, has also diverted Karat's focus from his high-stake fight against the UPA. Karat, on a firefighting mode, faxed Chatterjee's letter to West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya who rushed to Chatterjee's mentor Jyoti Basu asking him to intervene on the behalf of the party.

self is trying his persuasion skills with the NC.

Karat's plunge into street politics comes with a price. It has made him retract on contentious ideological issues. The CPI(M) had once termed Kanshi Ram a CIA agent and the BSP founder had returned the compliment by describing the Left as "green snake in the green grass". Even the draft of the political resolution circulated in the recent 19th party congress of the CPI(M) had said that "the victory of the BSP in Uttar Pradesh highlights the challenges posed by the growing political mobilisation based on caste identities". The reference to the BSP was diluted later when the political resolution was adopted at the party congress which, however, said that "a serious challenge is today posed by the growing political mobilisation based on caste identities".

Yet, so desperate is Karat to prevent the nuclear deal with the US from going through that such ideological compromises are now accept-

The air of desperation around Karat became

MORE EVIDENT AFTER CHATTERJEE ANNOUNCED

that he will not resign as the Speaker.

The issue of voting against the Government alongside the BJP is expected to come up for discussion in the Central Committee meet scheduled on the weekend. That doesn't mean the long knives are out for him, and Karat is expected to ram his decision through the CPI(M)'s most powerful body, when the party congress is not in session. Known for wariness to engage in political manoeuvres, Karat has transformed himself into a street fighter in a matter of a few days. Whether that new avatar makes him a better politician will be revealed on Tuesday. ■